

The Simple RACI Guide

Know who does the work, who makes the decision, and who needs to be kept in the loop.

Includes a worked example + blank template

Use this when approvals are slow, roles overlap, decisions keep bouncing around, or nobody is quite sure who owns the final call.

Free to use. Adapt it to your team.

What is RACI?

RACI is a simple way to make roles clear for a project, task or decision. Each person is given one of four roles.

Letter	Role	What it means
R	Responsible	Does the work.
A	Accountable	Owns the final decision and outcome.
C	Consulted	Gives input before the decision is made.
I	Informed	Needs to know what happened.

The important difference

Responsible and Accountable are not the same thing. Someone can do the work without owning the final decision. That distinction is where RACI becomes useful.

A good RACI should make work simpler. If the matrix creates more admin than the problem it solves, you probably do not need one.

When should you use it?

RACI is most useful when several people or teams are involved and ownership has become unclear.

- Approvals keep taking longer than they should.
- More than one person believes they have the final say.
- Work is repeatedly sent backwards and forwards.
- People are copied into every decision because nobody knows who actually needs to be involved.
- A task is delayed because everyone assumed someone else owned it.
- A project crosses teams, agencies, suppliers or client stakeholders.

When you probably do not need it

Do not build a RACI for every small task. If one person clearly owns the work and the decision path is already obvious, adding a matrix can slow things down.

A useful test

Ask: "If this gets stuck tomorrow, will everyone know who needs to act and who can make the final call?" If the answer is no, a RACI may help.

Worked example: a marketing campaign

A business is preparing a new campaign. The marketing lead manages the project, a designer creates the work, the CEO needs visibility, and the client approves the final campaign.

Task	Marketing lead	Designer	CEO	Client
Write campaign brief	R / A	I	I	C
Create designs	A	R	I	I
Review final work	R	C	I	A
Publish campaign	A	R	I	I

Why this works

The designer knows when they are doing the work and when they are only giving input. The marketing lead knows what they own. The CEO stays informed without becoming another approval step. The client has a clear point where final approval is required.

The exact letters will change from business to business. The goal is not to copy this example. The goal is to make the decision path obvious.

Build your own RACI

Start with the work, not the people. List the main tasks or decisions down the left. Then add the people or roles involved across the top.

Task / decision	Role 1	Role 2	Role 3	Role 4
1.				
2.				
3.				
4.				
5.				
6.				
7.				

Quick rules

- Aim for one clear Accountable person for each decision.
- Not everyone needs a letter in every row.
- Use roles where possible, not individual names, so the matrix survives staff changes.
- Keep it focused on decisions and handoffs that can genuinely cause confusion.
- Agree the matrix with the people involved before relying on it.

Before you put it into use

A RACI matrix is not a substitute for a good process. It simply makes ownership visible.

Check the A

Is there one person who clearly owns the final decision? Too many Accountable people usually means the decision is still unclear.

Check the R

Does someone clearly know they are expected to do the work? A task with no Responsible person has no owner.

Check the C

Are you consulting people because their input is genuinely needed, or because you are afraid to leave them out?

Check the I

Keep people informed without turning them into another approval step.

Keep it alive

Update the matrix when the project, team or decision process changes. An old RACI can be worse than no RACI.

The aim is simple: fewer unclear approvals, fewer duplicated decisions, and less time asking “who owns this?”

Tell a good story. Make it stick. Leave a mark.